



SUPRIYA VS SUNETRA (Left) Baramati sitting MP Supriya Sule with father Sharad Pawar; and Sunetra with husband Ajit

MANDAR DEODHAR

BJP was keen to get him since they felt Shinde would not deliver in the Lok Sabha election. Ajit's son Parth had lost the Lok Sabha election in 2019 from Maval, and a second successive defeat of a family member will be a major loss of face. Ajit has upped his stakes by hinting that he may stay away from contesting the assembly election in Maharashtra scheduled for later this year if his nominee does not make it to the Lok Sabha. Meanwhile, Pawar, 83, is fighting not just to ensure that his daughter retains her seat in Parliament, but also that his faction gets the popular mandate as the "real" NCP—contrary to the Election Commission's decision in favour of the Ajit-led camp, allowing it to use both the party name and clock symbol.

While Pawar has sympathy on his side following the rebellion of his nephew, Ajit has a strong grassroots connect in Baramati, according to party sources and locals. On their part, Sule and Sunetra have both jumped into the fray with all guns blazing. Both claim the election is more than family rivalry and what they offer the voters is a better tomorrow. Speaking to INDIA TODAY, Sule says, for her, the issues this election, are water scarcity, inflation, unemployment and corruption, and how "parties in Maharashtra were split using the agencies"—a reference to the alleged misuse of central agencies like the Enforcement Directorate (ED) by the party in power to target Opposition leaders. "A battle is a battle," said the sitting Baramati MP, when asked about whether this was a tough contest for her, denying that the Baramati election had turned into a personal battle with a family member ranged against her.

THE BATTLE IN BARAMATI IS BETWEEN SUPRIYA AND SUNETRA, BUT THE OUTCOME WILL DECIDE THE FUTURE OF SHARAD AND AJIT

Meanwhile, Sunetra said she was banking on her party's "development agenda" to win votes. "My candidature has come from the people...the people of the Baramati Lok Sabha constituency are my family," said Sunetra, speaking on the sidelines of her campaign at Lasurne in Indapur *taluka*, which is also part of the Baramati constituency. "Sympathy does not fill bellies. The coming generations will need development and employment for it," she added, when asked about the claim that sympathy for Pawar senior could influence the electoral outcome. "My only agenda is *vikas* [development] and I am seeking votes on it," said Sunetra.

The differences within the Pawars are driving a wedge between families and friends in Katewadi. Among them